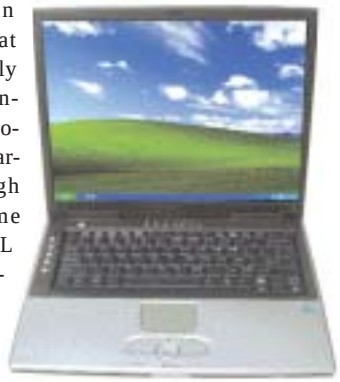
BPL Notebook

Full of ergonomic glitches



The BPL Notebook has an Intel Pentium M running at 1.3 GHz and a measly 128 MB of DDR RAM. Using Windows XP on this laptop is an agonising experience, which was clearly reflected in the scores. Though the Zenith laptop also had the same CPU, it zoomed ahead of the BPL in the ZDbench Business Winstone system benchmark test owing to its 256 MB of RAM.

The 40 GB hard drive is a welcome move, but a combo-drive would be better than the DVD-ROM it has. Although based on a Centrino platform, the laptop offers optional wireless connectivity. It's silvery body and oddly coloured blue translucent keys aren't impressive either. At 2.7 Kg, it's heavy but not too bulky.

Ergonomically, the keyboard and touchpad are comfortable. The layout of the keys is spacious. The optical drive is placed on the bevelled edge in the front, but the eject button does not protrude making access to the drive all the more difficult; the scroll pad lacks tactile feel. The control keys for the Audio DJ function are located near the bottom of the screen. Hence, you need to flip open the top every time you want to skip a song. Ideally, these controls should have been placed at the edges. Other nifty features include flash memory readers for SD and MMC cards.

The BPL notebook pitched in an average performance. Compared to other laptops, it had fairly good scores in the CPU benchmarks, but the Business Winstone scores were pathetic.

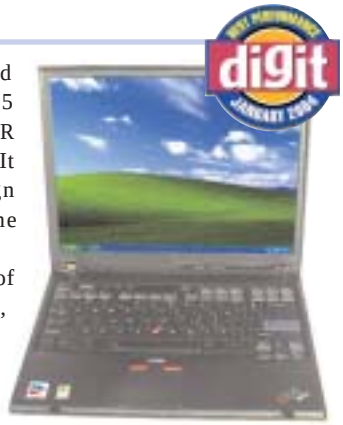
It finished second in the battery-life test—the battery lasted for almost 5 hours. It's quite expensive at Rs 85,000, so we don't recommend it taking into account its ergonomic issues and the below par configuration.

Price: Rs 85,000
+ Slim design
– Full of ergonomic flaws

BPL Notebook	B
Performance	
Features	
Usability	
Value for money	

IBM T40

The FORTeeeee



The IBM T40 we received comprised a Pentium M 1.5 GHz with 256 MB of DDR RAM and a 40 GB hard drive. It weighs only 2.2 Kg. The design makes good use of space , and the attention to detail is exemplary.

A thumb slider on the right of the lid actuates the two latches, and a grip on the left side lets you hold it firmly. The combo-drive is housed in a slot on the right and has a step design with the eject button on the lower step to avoid accidental popping. Ergonomically, the T40 has hardly a flaw, except for the missing Windows key—but you can configure [Ctrl] or [Alt] to act as one. It has a touchpad with two small buttons and a pointing stick.

It has innovative features such as a night lamp incorporated above the screen. No recovery CDs are provided, but its factory defaults are present on the hard drive. Access these by pressing the blue IBM Access button during bootup. These allow you to re-partition, format, install the OS and other software. Use IBM's Rapid Restore software to backup data and retrieve it from the special menu itself.

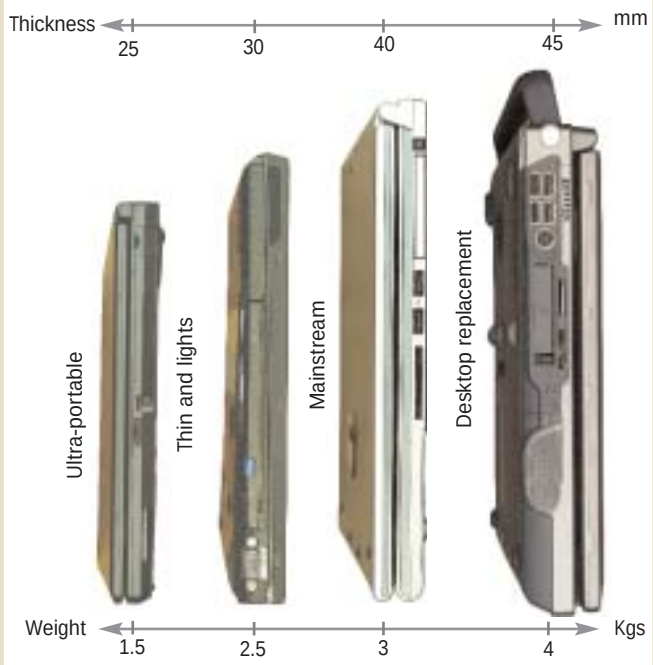
The IBM T40 topped most of the tests. The Business Winstone saw it return 27.7 units, making it ideal for business applications such as MS-Office etc. In *Quake III Arena*, the ATi Radeon 7500 yield extremely good results, posting 229 fps in normal mode—the best in the entire category.

It topped the list when all other criteria such as usability, package content, etc., were considered, and thus bagged the title.

The fully charged batteries last for nearly 3 and a half hours. Rs 1,70,000 makes it expensive, but you get more than what you're paying for. We have no qualms in offering it the crown that it deserves.

Price: Rs 1,69,900
+ Great design, superb performance
– Expensive

IBM T40	C-
Performance	
Features	
Usability	
Value for money	

Through Thick and Thin

We categorised the laptops that came in for the test based on their thickness and weight.